

personality observed by Erik Erikson holds also for Sen: the capacity to look at people from the rest of the world neither from below nor above, but eye to eye.

One of the most important figures in the intellectual history of independent India, he has achieved this status principally in the capacity of an economist functioning from within an academic environment. While economics falls somewhere in between the "hard" and the "soft" sciences, Sen's popularity is significantly larger than of the "middling" magnitude one might expect, given that mainstream economics has tended to cast itself in the mould of an abstract and logically demanding discipline in the tradition of the mathematical sciences, and that Sen's "popular" writings—unlike those of certain other intellectuals—lack the appeal of gossip (however elevated) that comes from dealing with personalities rather than issues. Indeed, it is possible that the combination of recondite-ness and popularity that characterises Sen is comparable only to that of John Maynard Keynes.

There are many reasons for his fame. Trained in Calcutta's Presidency College and at Cambridge University, Sen became a professor at the age of 22 (at Jadavpur University), and went on to hold permanent positions and chairs at the Delhi School of Economics, the London School of Economics, and at the universities of Oxford, Cambridge and Harvard, apart from receiving any number of visiting positions and honorary doctorates, and, in 1998, being awarded the Nobel Prize for Economics. His versatility relates not only to topics within economics, but to topics without: apart from having always displayed a keen analytical interest in history, he has also worked extensively in moral and political philosophy and is, indeed, a professor of both economics and philosophy at Harvard.

But for all the formal honours (in-



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Q: Which famous person does Amartya Sen owe his name to?

A: Rabindranath Tagore

Q: What prompted Sen's first famous essay on poverty?

A: Personal experience. When he was nine, he witnessed the Bengal famine of 1943.

Q: Which index of development did he help create?

A: The Human Development Index

Q: What are Sen's favourite pastimes?

A: Long bicycle rides, reading and arguing with people

Q: Which organisation did he set up with part of the Nobel money?

A: Pratiche! Trust that conducts primary research in health and education in India

cluding, for good measure, a Bharat Ratna) which this country has bestowed on Sen, the substantive acknowledgement of his endeavours by its intelligentsia is disappointing, even angering. It is almost alarming that the Beautiful People of our society, without an ounce of genuine sensitivity, have learnt to mouth Sen-inspired catch-phrases like "entitlement failure", "capability deprivation", and "development as freedom". Given the levels of deprivation and disparity that surround one, it would be a poor way of recalling Sen's life's work to follow the injunction of Percival Christopher Wren who, on the subject of a memorial to himself, is supposed to have said, when standing inside St Paul's Cathedral in the city of London: "Look ye around".

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